



Talaera's English Guide for Customer Success: Increase User Satisfaction Through Better Communication



A Guide For CSM

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Great communication is at the heart of every awesome customer success team!

As a customer success manager, you are in one of the most in-demand jobs on the market. Big companies know that great CSM teams can hugely influence key company metrics like user churn, retention, adoption rates, and are crucial for fostering meaningful customer relationships. But they will only hire the best of the best. This means that there is fierce competition to get hired for one of the top-paying jobs.

One essential skill that sets the top international candidates apart is their **communication ability in English**. This is often confused with language ability. But language ability is just your command of grammar and vocabulary. Communicative ability goes much further. In fact, this communicative ability is one of the most sought after skills among CSMs. But why? And how can it help you land your dream job?

Communication ability is at the heart of all successful CSM teams. Big names like Google want a CSM team that thrives. And they know this happens when team members collaborate well: excellent communication ensures that issues are resolved quickly and efficiently, product demos go smoothly, and CSMs can upsell when needed.

You don't have to be a grammar nerd. Effective communication is more to do with your ability to describe a problem clearly and concisely and communicate this to users and team members. Annoyingly, while this may come naturally to you in your native language, in English this often takes much more practice.

But it's worth the effort. Not only will these communication skills put you on the radar of your dream company, but they have a host of other benefits, too.

Get that promotion. For better or worse, performance reviews at major tech companies are heavily biased towards English native-speakers. So the better your English, the more likely it is that you will get that promotion.

Make yourself future-proof. Companies are going global and increasingly looking to international hires. As English is the lingua franca in the tech world, the quicker you start improving your English, the faster you'll be future-proof. If you think learning English is already a must-have now, how important do you think it will be in five years?

This Talaera English guide will help you understand the most pressing communication challenges non-native customer success managers face. We will also provide practical steps for boosting your English skills and landing your dream job. Happy reading!

Chapter 1

What Are The Biggest Communication Challenges As A Non-Native Customer Success Manager?



As a non-native customer success manager, you face a lot of challenges. One of the main ones is communication. So, we talked to some of our CSM students to find their biggest language struggles. Our research shows that the following six are the **main language challenges** that you will encounter. Can you relate to any of these?

1. It's harder to succeed in an interview at your dream company

"Every key skill revolves around communication."

As a CSM, communication ability is the **number one skill that top companies look for**. Whether it's building customer relationships, solving support issues, or mediating between the company and the client, **every key skill revolves around communication**.

This means that top companies use interviews to assess your communication skills. Questions will often test your ability to describe, explain, and express yourself clearly. Top companies want candidates who can collaborate with other stakeholders like sales, tech support, or product managers as efficiently as possible. This means that as a non-native speaker, it's much harder to pass these interviews because your skills are likely not as good as in your native language.

There is also another challenge to overcome: **native speaker bias**. This is where the hiring manager subconsciously prefers native speakers over you. Not because they are better at the job than you, rather but because this bias causes HR managers to classify similar accents as their own as better than foreign ones. So even if you give a great answer, the interviewer may not rate you as highly due to your foreign accent. What does this all mean? This means that communication is even more important for you as non-native speakers if you want that dream job.



2. You're less likely to get an internal promotion

Companies all claim to treat everybody equally. But this doesn't mean that they can eliminate subconscious bias towards non-native speakers. Everything from your foreign accent to your grammar mistakes shape how your native-speaker colleagues see you. This bias means that it will be **harder for you to get that internal promotion.**

This is because performance reviews and ability assessments are biased towards native-speakers - they are written and carried out in English. In addition, companies often use KPIs (see point 4 below) to choose who should get promoted. As a CSM, many of your KPIs depend on your communication ability, so you may fall short of native speaker colleagues. This disadvantages you when it comes to promotion time.



3. You experience misunderstandings with other team members

On a CSM team, collaboration is key. Whether it's talking to tech support about a client issue, dealing with sales to upsell a customer, or communication within the team to delegate tasks - communication is the glue that holds the CSM team together. It is also what differentiates a highly efficient team from an inefficient one.

Not only this but there is a ton of written communication involved in CSM work such as emails, or Slack messages. With all this communication, there is a lot of potential for misunderstandings, ranging from the relatively harmless to the more serious. And how you communicate matters. Clients (as well as other team members) judge your competency based on your communication. Either way, **a team member with poor communication ability can really slow impact customer satisfaction and team efficiency.** This is not good when the team has specific targets to hit.

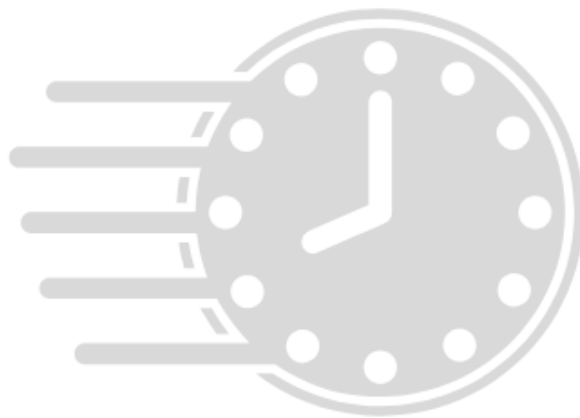


4. You are slower to resolve support issues

This is not necessarily true. In fact, many non-native speaker CSMs are just as good if not better than native speakers. But there are tasks where poor communication can slow you down. These include:

- **Finding and distributing the right resources** - searching and reading documentation in a foreign language is slower than in your own
- **Communicating with clients** - as a non-native speaker, you are extra careful about proof-reading any communication to clients. But this also takes extra time.

Overall, this means that CSMs with weaker communication skills are more likely to have slightly worse KPIs like time taken to resolve support issues.



5. Your client-facing communication will seem less professional

Even if you are naturally a great communicator in your native language, this takes time to master in English. But clients judge your ability as a CSM based on your communication skills. The following are areas where poor communication can have a negative effect:

- **Training users and onboarding** - clients want to understand how to use all key product features quickly. This requires the ability to explain things clearly and concisely.
- **Product demos** - often explaining products is quite tricky, particularly in the tech sector. Great communication helps this.
- **Resolving issues** - clients with support issues may be quicker to get frustrated when dealing with someone with weaker communication skills.
- **Upselling** - CSMs are often expected to identify upsell opportunities. Closing upsell deals requires a fine balance between maintaining existing client relationships and identifying a genuine upsell opportunity.

But all of these factors affect the company's churn and user retention rates. This means that managers keep a close eye on the CSM team and expect them to deliver.



6. It is harder to delight your users

All of the above factors combined mean that it is harder to delight your users. This is tough because this is your primary mission as a CSM. But if your accent is hard to understand, or you don't speak with confidence, then the feedback that your users leave is likely to be less flattering. And this is a vicious circle: the worse your feedback, the less likely you are to get a promotion or impress your team leader.



Phew! The worst is over now. Let's move on to the more positive stuff!

Chapter 2

What Are The Main Benefits Of Great English Communication Skills?



We'd all love to speak perfect English. But finding the motivation can sometimes be tough. Based on our own successful students working in customer success at some of the big-name companies, we have compiled a list of the main benefits of great communication they have enjoyed due to boosting their English skills. **Often looking at the benefits makes it easier to find the motivation to commit to learning.**

1. Earn more money by landing your dream job

Great CSM is all about communication. The ability to describe, explain, empathize, and resolve. And the big-name companies design their interviews to test exactly this ability and use it as a benchmark for their candidates. So commit to boosting your English skills, and you will dramatically improve your chances of landing that dream job.

And even if you don't get a callback from your dream company, improved communication will help you get an internal promotion. Most employee reviews are held in English, so give yourself an edge over your international colleagues.

2. Impress your team leader and get a promotion

In the previous chapter, we highlighted some disadvantages that non-native CSMs face. But the good news is, you can overcome most of these by improving your communication skills.

When it comes to getting that promotion, your team leader will look at your KPIs and feedback users leave. The better your communication, the better your user feedback will be. **Boosting your communication skills is one of the best ways to impress your team leader and get promoted.**

3. Make team communication more efficient

One key part of your role as a CSM is **collaboration**. You often function as a go-between, linking multiple teams and departments together.

With improved communication, you will get much more confident in collaborating with other team members, reporting to team leaders and in dealing with other teams like sales, product or tech support. This confidence, combined with great communication, is a winning combination and will help you excel in your role as a CSM.

4. Resolve user issues quicker

Get more done quicker. Resolving a support issue can involve many different steps. But all of them can be sped up by boosting your communications skills. From reading through user docs more quickly, to finding the right resources, improved communication will save you time.

Also, when it comes to client communication, you will be able to confidently and quickly type emails and Slack messages. Taken together, this can improve your performance metrics.

5. Give better product demos and find more upselling opportunities

As a CSM, client communication is a central part of your role. During onboarding, you may give a product demo. Your goal is to explain the product to your users as clearly and effectively as possible.

The better you can explain product features and key details, then the better your demos will be. Not only this, but the better you will be at upselling to users. Upselling is a delicate balance of fostering a relationship with users and informing them of other useful features available to them. This requires nuanced communication skills, meaning the stronger your skills, the better you will be able to upsell.

6. Delight your users and get better feedback

CSMs with strong communication skills are more likely to delight their users. Why? The better you can communicate, the more professional your communication will appear. You will be able to understand their needs more quickly, creating a sense of empathy and trust.

And **how your users actually perceive you is really important.** The better your communication, the more competent you will come across. This means that over time, your feedback from users will also be better. Better user feedback puts you in a better position for both internal promotions and for applying to a major company. More than enough reason to improve your communication skills!

Chapter 3

What Can You Do To Boost Your Communication Skills?



Talaera specializes in helping global tech professionals improve their communication. We have developed many effective strategies to help our students working in CSM to achieve their goals. The next **six learning solutions** are some of the most effective to help you boost your skills today.

Tip #1

1. Always learn English in context

One of the main reasons people struggle to learn a language is lack of context. Traditional teaching methods focus on grammar, and the context is simply taken from the class textbook.

But you need to create your own learning context. Take a problem you already want to solve and try solving it in English. For example, you could focus on learning phrases that help you with giving product demos. This means you learn specific vocabulary in a context that you can use later. This will give structure to your learning, and you'll also be more motivated to get through it.

Extra tip: when learning vocabulary, use each word in a sentence that you would actually use in your life. Then, imagine yourself in that situation and read it out loud.

Tip #2

2. Break your learning up into mini-goals

Learning English can be daunting for anyone. But breaking it up into manageable chunks can make it seem much less intimidating and even improve your learning rate. Think about what you actually need to know and find a small, bite-size topic.

One of our students recently said she wanted to learn the correct way to use time phrases. This was important to her for scheduling product demos. Having this specific mini-goal helps to focus your learning.

This is a type of **problem you can solve in less than thirty minutes**. So, start by creating a list of the things you would like to learn (time phrases, email greetings, common phrases used in product demos). Now, you can systematically begin to fill in the gaps in your knowledge. There are a lot of great articles online - like on the [Talaera blog](#) - that can help you achieve these mini-goals.

Tip #3

3. Find a learning partner and create an English learning #channel

Perhaps there is someone on your team that is in the same situation as you. Why not get together help each other improve your English? You can motivate each other to learn and add structure to your learning. You can even join a Slack channel with other English learners, or create your own. This is a great way to find and share interesting resources.



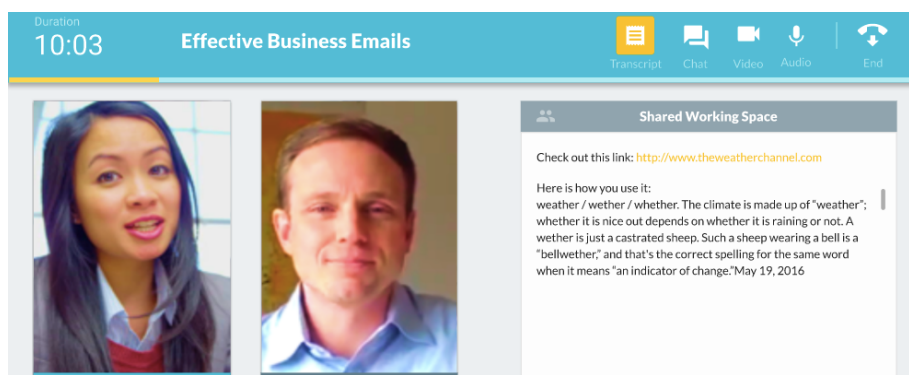
Tip #4

4. Get your talent manager to invest in language training

Investing in language training pays off, and companies know it. Customer success managers at Paypal, Google, Gett, and Check Point are already enjoying Talaera's custom English training for tech professionals.

We focus on communication ability. Talaera enables you to communicate with colleagues and focus on real-life problems: big picture stuff. And the best part is, you don't even have to pay for it yourself. **Win-win!**

So why not tell your talent manager to add English training to the list of personal development opportunities? If they need some convincing, share this ebook with them.



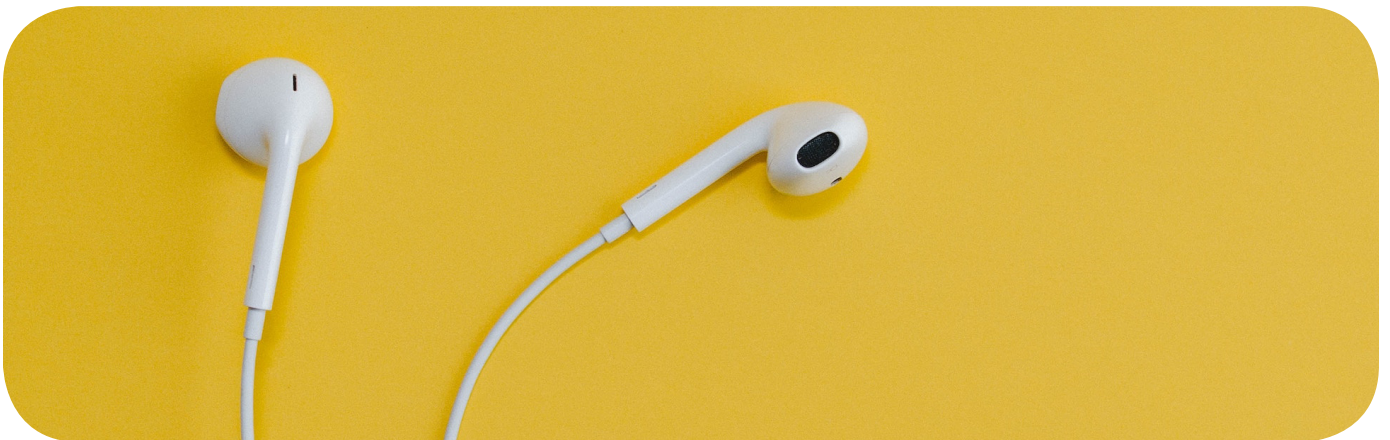
Extra tip: Talaera offers individual online business English for employees in the global workplace. It's much more than English training -improve presentation skills, negotiations, dealing with customers, cross-cultural business communication, and much more. Learn more [here](#).

Tip #5

5. Audio shadowing using the power of the podcast

Do you listen to any podcasts in English? If so, then try the following **easy method to quickly improve your pronunciation**: play a podcast and find a piece of audio. A relatively simple phrase works best. Repeat this piece of English out loud right after you hear the audio. Just imitate the voice without thinking about the meaning too much. Repeat this a few times. Try and do this every morning and over time, you will train your ear to pronounce words more accurately. And if people at the metro stop to look at you weirdly, just tell them it's for a good cause!

The reason podcasts work so well is because there is no visual to distract you. But feel free to try this simple method with all audio or even TV shows you like.





Conclusion

Whichever way you look it at, **learning English is a crucial skill for you as a customer success manager.** CSMs at top companies are expected to give amazing product demos, resolve support issues quickly, and upsell to users. This all relies on excellent communication. And companies like these only hire the cream of the crop, so boosting your communication skills is an absolute must. It may even land you your dream job. What is will do for certain is give you the power to delight your users, and in doing so, your company.

The workforce is becoming increasingly international. With companies having global ambitions, great English communication has never been as important or as desirable in CSM jobs. And with all that competition out there, the benchmark for CSM communication skills is only going to get higher. **So in order to give yourself an edge, you need to have great English skills.**

Learning English will diversify your skills and put you ahead of the rest. So add improving English your goals for this year!

And why not partner with the best in the business? Talaera already helps customer success managers at many successful international companies. Better still, get your company to pay for it.

Let your talent manager know today that you're interested in English classes.



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talk!

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